



▲ Indonesian rituals

This Toraja priestess is dressed for a religious ceremony. Women play an essential role in the rituals of the Toraja, an ethnic group that lives in the Sulawesi province of highland Indonesia.

By the 6th century, there were groups of Christian women across Europe, North Africa, and West Asia who had withdrawn from the secular world to devote themselves to religious life. Over time, different religious orders developed, each with their own rules and customs. These women often faced suspicion from church authorities, who believed their gender made them more susceptible to sin. It was also feared that nuns were mentally and physically unable to live by the same guidelines as men, although in practice they often did.

Freedom in the convent

Before the 19th century, convents were one of the few places where women had some responsibility for their own governance and, in the double monasteries of the Middle Ages, could even have powers over monks. In convents, communal obligations were placed above individual ones; there was time set aside for private prayer, but it could not interfere with other duties, the most important of which was the daily schedule of prayer and singing hymns. In many convents nuns made goods for sale outside the community to help pay for day-to-day expenses. Nunneries were also active as centers of education (today the largest order of nuns is the teaching order of Salesian Sisters), medical care, and charitable works. Nunneries remain important in both the Catholic and Orthodox branches of Christianity. However, they are less significant in Protestantism, despite a small resurgence since the mid-19th century.



PROFILES

NUNS AND PRIESTESSES

Hildegard of Bingen (c. 1098–1179) experienced religious visions from a young age, and by her teens had entered a cloistered community of nuns at a Benedictine monastery in western Germany. The nuns elected Hildegard as their leader, and in 1147 she founded a separate convent nearby. She wrote works of theology and science, and also composed music.

Sun Bu'er (c. 1119–1182) became a Taoist priestess at the age of 51. She traveled throughout China, splashing hot oil on her face to disfigure herself and deter molesters, and found inner enlightenment. She became a prominent religious leader with a group of female followers. After her death, she is said to have become an immortal.

Herrad of Landsberg (c. 1130–1195) came from a noble Alsatian family and entered Hohenburg Abbey, France, then famed as a center of learning. She was elected its abbess in 1167, and held the office until her death. Herrad also compiled *Hortus deliciarum* (*Garden of Delights*)—an encyclopedic work about science and theology.

Catherine of Siena (1347–1380) decided to devote herself to a religious life at the age of 16, when she refused to marry her late sister's widower. She joined the Dominican order, but lived at home and worked to help the needy. Following a religious vision when she was 21, Catherine took on a more public role, traveling across Italy, preaching peace and religious reform.

Regina Jonas (1902–1944) was born in Berlin. After studying the Torah, Talmud, and other sources, in 1935 she persuaded a liberal rabbi to ordain her, and led services. In 1942, the Nazis deported Jonas to Theresienstadt (in what is now Terezín, Czechia) concentration camp; two years later she was murdered at Auschwitz.

Tenzin Palmo (b. 1943) was born in England, but moved to India, where she took a new name and was ordained a novice Tibetan Buddhist nun. A decade later she was fully ordained, and lived as the only nun in an all-male monastery.